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Bill Berry and Buster Cooper

Bill Berry and Buster Cooper have both been mainstays in the brass section of the famed Duke Ellington Orchestra. Bill's trumpet sound was familiar in the studios and jazz groups of New York until the Merv Griffin Orchestra moved to the west coast. He became a top session player in the Los Angeles studios and continues to lead the Bill Berry Big Band and appear at jazz festivals and parties.

In his 35 years of trombone playing, Buster Cooper has played with Ellington, Benny Carter, Woody Herman, Lionel Hampton and Benny Goodman. He currently makes his home in Florida.

Bill and Buster both appeared with the Statesmen of Jazz in their performance at the 1995 Los Angeles Classic Jazz Festival. They were interviewed by Michael Woods in Los Angeles on September 3, 1995. Monk Rowe participated briefly in the interview.

MW: We are filming interviews with America's greatest jazz men for the Hamilton College Jazz Archives. And we are blessed today to have two fabulous musicians from a newly formed group called the Statesmen of Jazz. Bill Berry and Buster Cooper. Pleased to have you gentlemen. Tell us how you got started playing the trumpet.

BB: Well let's see — how I got started. Well I always wanted to play. Actually I wanted to play trombone but Buster got that. But I pestered my folks until they bought me a horn for Christmas one year, and I've been playing the thing ever since.

MW: How was the music in the school systems? Did that help?

BB: I had a very good music teacher in high school but my parents were also musicians.

MW: And how about yourself on the trombone? What led you to the trombone?

BC: Pardon?

MW: What led you to the trombone?

BC: Well I've been trying to figure that out for a long time. Anyway, so what happened was I started out on drums first, because my cousin, he used to play in Erskine Hawkin's band, you know, way before your time. And so I mean he idolized him. He used to come home with all different kinds of stories, I mean because went all over the state, in Alabama, you know. So he used to come back off the road and tell of the good times he had, and who he met and this and that. And I always did idolize him, you know, secretly anyway. And so well I mean actually I got hung up on baseball first. I wanted to be a baseball player, like all American boys, you understand what I'm saying? And then my brother, he started playing trumpet. So I went to the music shop with my dad one time, to pick up my

my dad did. So I've been still trying to learn the darn thing, you know. It's really something else.

BB: Well that's one of the great parts about music, is you never know it all. Always, every day something is learned.

BC: Exactly. I practice four and five hours a day sometimes. Every day. I mean I practice every day, naturally. Even on the road, you know you have to. I mean it's an old saying but it's a true saying if you miss a day, okay now you can tell it, and if you miss another day, the teacher can tell it, and if you miss another one the audience can tell it. So I mean that's just the way it goes.

BB: You've got to understand that you never, not only do you never learn it, but you've never got it down perfect either. Ever. Every time you pick the thing up it's a challenge.

BC: That's right. Because that's why you hardly ever see or hear of a professional musician retiring. Never. I mean because all, we kind of grasp for that particular sound or that goal, you know, whatever it might be, you know, you understand?

MW: And then in jazz, there are so many parameters that you have to bring under your personal control. Because when you solo, you have to say it all.

BC: Well actually, you know, that's one great thing about improvisation. When you're taking like a solo. Okay, you're standing on your feet composing. But it might look easy to the average person. But it's not that way. In other words, to make a long story short, you have to have a little bit of smarts in order to play an instrument.

MW: You know there were people when, in the early days of jazz that used to think that jazz musicians were just, I don't know what they thought, were in some type of a trance or something or whatever. Every jazz musician that can take two choruses over a 32-bar form, is a theoretician.

BC: Exactly. I'll grant you that. I like that term, too.

MW: Tell us some of the early bands that you played with, how you got your start professionally.

BC: Well I started with my cousin's big band, I mean, but first, I was born and raised in St. Petersburg, Florida. And then I went to high school, you know, the same thing, the teacher in the high school band, the teacher and stuff like that. And my cousin had a 16-piece band you know. So naturally blood is thicker than water so he let me ease in there some kind of way, you know. So after I finished high school like in St. Petersburg, I went to New York you know. And my first big band was Lionel Hampton's band you know. And it had within that band it had Clifford Brown, Art Farmer and Quincy Jones and like big names you know. I mean it's big names now. Nowadays, guys like Benny Golson, Alan Dawson, Monk Montgomery, Wes Montgomery's brother. And it was a fine band

but we weren't making no money but the band sure was swinging. You understand what I'm saying?

BB: Wasn't nobody out of Hamp's band making any money.

BC: It sure was swinging, but I mean actually I mean, at the time so I mean Quincy Jones, I mean he was about 16 years old. I mean but he always did, I'll use the term take care of business. He was always, always stepping. And he's still stepping for his as far as I'm concerned as far as Quincy Jones goes, because that's his thing. He was a fabulous musician and is a fabulous musician I should say. But he's doing a lot of producing now, you know, for different T.V. shows and everything else.

MW: Movie scores.

BC: Yeah, exactly.

MW: Tell us one of your early bands.

BB: Oh, well when I got out of high school, they used to have what they call territory bands, which meant just what it sounds like, they were bands that only worked a certain small area of maybe one or two states period. And there were so many ballrooms in those days that these bands worked, literally worked six nights a week and you didn't repeat yourself for six months. You never got back to the same — and this was all like in Iowa and Nebraska in this case. And there were dozens of these bands. And they were not very good bands, but they were working all the time, every night. And they used to advertise in *Down Beat* magazine. They used to have a classified section and they would say Needed: you know like, first trumpet, third trombone, saxophone and a telephone number or whatever. And that's how I got my first job, by answering an ad in *Down Beat*.

BC: Well speaking of territory bands, you know, I don't know if you ever heard a band by the name of Nat Towles?

BB: Oh, sure. He worked out of the same office we worked out of, Vic Schrader's.

BC: Oh really? Well anyway I had just left Florida, this was my first time leaving Florida, this was in 1949. And his headquarters is in Omaha, Nebraska.

BB: Right, right. Vic Schrader. That was the name of the agency.

BC: Really? Uh huh. So we used to play places like Bismark, North Dakota and all different places like that.

BB: Were you on that band?

BC: Um hum.

BB: Nat Towles? I'll be darned. When?

BC: 1949.

BB: Oh, see [inaudible].

BC: You're kidding. Oh, that's beautiful. 1949. Because Alvin Nisson was on the band. Well

make it with this band and everything. And all of a sudden I saw something white coming out of the sky, and I'd never seen snow before in my life, you understand what I'm saying? And so I say hey, wait a minute —

BB: These bands incidentally, had what they called sleeper bus bands.

BC: Yeah, that's right.

BB: And they had, they'd take a truck or a bus and convert it with bunks.

BC: Yeah, with sleepers on it.

BB: And boy were those things funky. We used to check into a hotel every Monday. That was our day off, to take a bath. The rest of the week you lived in the bus. Period. We never checked in. Right, Buster?

BC: Oh, absolutely.

BB: And it was, in the wintertime we had to carry our own drinking water and all that, in the wintertime the water in the bus, the drinking water would freeze it was so cold in the bus. But we lived in the thing.

BC: Yeah, that was my first time ever seeing snow, so I mean I guess I lasted about another week.

BB: Well they do have some weather out there in Nebraska and in Iowa too.

BC: Oh, man, in Bismark, North Dakota, places like that, you know. Oh, and it's stormy, really.

BB: Yeah, that's exactly what, that's exactly what was experienced. And now, unfortunately, there is no place to get that experience.

BC: That's right.

BB: Now all the kids are going to college because now that they teach jazz in college, okay. But that's not the same thing as being on the road.

MW: I want to ask you, I want to follow in on that and ask for some comparisons there. Because this music is experiential.

BB: Yes you have to have something to play about.

MW: And I want you to talk about that. Because then I'm going to ask you a little later about some questions about some of the marvelous big bands that you played with. But at that time you had the university of Basie. The university of Ellington.

BB: Well but that's the tops. You don't start out at the top you know.

MW: Well take us to prep school then.

BB: Well you just do something, you know it's like anything else you do, the more you live, the more experience you get and the more you know what's going on hopefully. And that's what that stuff was all about. They weren't good bands, but they were bands. And I really feel sorry for the young people now as far as that goes. Because there is no warm-

up place like that. There's no place to get that experience you know. And you can't get out of high school and go straight with Count Basie's band.

BC: Well actually, Billy and I, we had the experience and the feeling of that, going to clubs and jamming, you know, like jazz clubs.

BB: That's another thing, yeah.

BC: You know like jamming, and the guys would let you sit in if they are nice, you understand what I'm saying? But I mean you don't find that nowadays. A kid will come out of high school or maybe the Berklee or something like that, you know. But it's nothing like I mean in other words hearing it in the street, let's put it that way, I mean because that's where jazz comes from you know, from the street, you know. Because the blackboard can't talk. But I'm not putting the schools down at all, talking about hands-on experiences. It's just fabulous you know.

MW: I want to ask you another question about this. In a time when there wasn't that much racial mixing, they say that at night after the bands got through, all the players would get together and jam anyhow because they all wanted to play together. Talk to us about how the music made a bridge there.

BB: Well that business of segregation was never the musicians' idea. You know this is the one thing where you didn't have that happening. Although it was illegal in some places, literally illegal.

BC: If you're on the wrong side of town, or anytime at that time night or day and you saw the cops, they'd say hey, what you doing in this district vice versa you know. But anyway, they always find a way to merge. It never fails in I mean musicians. I mean it's not that ethnic in there, you know, believe me. You understand what I'm saying? It's not there, and never has been, not among musicians, not in my experience.

MW: What does the jam session do that the classroom doesn't do?

BC: Experience.

BB: Experience with an audience. Also like I'm sure with Bus it's the same thing, I used to sit in these joints and you know, you're playing with people all the time who are better than you are. And that's the only way to learn it. You go, like, if you're the best kid in the band, then you're in trouble because there's nobody to learn from. You should always try to play with people who are better than you are, so that some of that rubs off on you hopefully.

MW: Jump in over your head.

BB: Amen. Swim or sink, you know. And well it's like in the Bird movie. He goes in, he can't play, they get rid of him, "get out of here." Well, go home and practice and then come back later. He sure did.

BC: But actually I mean well I consider myself, and I'm quite sure that Bill would be the same way, that we are very fortunate to make a living at music. I mean I feel blessed.

BB: Oh, you and me both, yeah.

BC: Because I mean, okay I mean, I'd have to say I mean it's not that many, it's like a kid with a basketball. You see the kids all the time and it's just like basketball. You know there's nothing wrong with that I mean because it's just determination, like anything else. If you put on blinders and say I'm going to be the best musician, the best trumpet player, the best basketball player. But the kids nowadays, it's only maybe about twelve major league teams you know? And I mean how many can get on those teams and everything? I mean okay, we happened to be lucky we could make a living out of it and still making a living out of it. That's very fortunate.

MW: Talk to us about your work together in the Ellington band. Talk to us about what made that band one of the most fabulous ensembles that's ever existed.

BC: Exactly. I'll grant you that.

BB: Or THE. I mean Buster can tell you this, corroborate it or anybody else, everybody from Count Basie on down said, you know, I mean there was no question, Duke was it. He was the champ. And it was not a question of rivalry or anything like that, because Ellington had everything covered hands down. There wasn't even any competition. It was every musician's—

BC: Dream.

BB: favorite. And that band didn't operate like any other band. I've been on lots and lots of bands. That one didn't operate like any of the other ones at all. Nobody else could even begin to operate like that. Like the guys used to get up in the middle of a tune and go off to make a phone call or get a drink or something. Nobody ever said anything. Not a word. Now if you did that on anybody else's band, you'd be fired immediately.

BC: Exactly.

BB: You know, to get up in the middle of a tune and walk off?

BC: Well one thing I can say about Duke I mean he was not a disciplinarian. By no means. He'd say, "Everybody's a man." Or he didn't fire you, and I mean well he gave one guy notice, that was the first time I'd ever seen that. But anyway, okay now what happened to me, I had met him when I was like in Paris you know. I had the group behind the Josephine Baker show, you know, my brother and I, and the old Olympia Theater like in Paris. So and the band was like in town so they came by the see the group. And they just kind of hit on me then, you know, for coming with the band. And so when I got back to New York I was playing night clubs around New York, right, Count Basie's Club and Small's Paradise, in my group. So he called me one time, for a couple of gigs, but I

couldn't make them. So he called me up for one weekend, you know to make Friday, Saturday, Sunday, over in Cherry Hill, New Jersey you know.

BB: The Red Hill Inn.

BC: Yes. Exactly. So that's where it starts. So my first night, no my third night, I—

BB: His first night was Upstate New York somewhere.

BC: That's right. That's right. We had a wreck.

BB: We had a head-on collision Buster's first night.

BC: Remember that?

BB: Betty got hurt, and the bus driver.

BC: And it's like what happened, okay, he was on the edge of the cliff, you know—

BB: Overlooking the water.

BC: And okay now we had to get a school bus, you know, one of the school buses, to go into New York City, and we had to record that morning.

BB: And we were standing out on the highway for hours, and finally an old rickety school bus comes and picks us up, and drives us straight to the record studio. It doesn't matter that we had a wreck or anything like that, we'd go to the record date and make the record.

BC: Could I just say one thing about Duke? Anytime we was off, if we were off for a month, we'd record for a month. That's the way it seems.

BB: Yes. It seemed like every time we had a day off or something we were making another record. I mean always. There are still records of Ellington's that are coming out that I'm on that have never been released yet.

BC: Exactly.

BB: And I don't know how many we made.

BC: Oh, man, goodness. Really something else.

BB: But you're right. Every time there was a day off there was a record date.

BC: Yeah. It was something else.

MW: Two tunes, tell us about these two tunes. Tell us about "Take the A Train." Why is it every time that tune is played, all over the world, anywhere, it has immediate rapport with audiences?

BB: Everybody knows it, yeah.

MW: And then "It Don't Mean a Thing."

BB: The introduction. You don't even have to get into the melody. You play the piano introduction and everybody starts applauding.

BC: That's Strayhorn's tune, huh? Billy Strayhorn. Yeah. That's something else.

BB: You know it's just one of those ones that everybody loves. I don't know why.

BC: Well it seems to me like a perfect collaboration. And okay, Duke and Strayhorn was fantastic. I've seen Duke, he started tunes, he'd say, "Here, Stray, I can't turn the corner now on this one. Fix this for me." You can tell.

BB: Or over the phone. "Strayhorn, I'm stuck here, you know with this, do something with it," and the way the stories go I'm sure it's true, is Strayhorn would send something out that was like perfect, like as though they were reading each other's minds.

BC: Exactly. Fantastic.

BB: The perfect solution, you know. Also, Duke Ellington was the — how do you say this — he was the smartest, brightest person I've ever met. Period.

BC: Exactly. I used to sit and watch him man and I'd try and figure him out, you know. I used to be looking at him and he was always — he didn't wear a watch or nothing like that because he didn't even know what the time was. That didn't mean nothing. I guess he thought maybe that'd make you rush through the day, you understand what I'm saying? And I used to sit up on the bandstand and I'd just watch him you know. And I finally came to the conclusion one night. I said Duke Ellington knows who Duke is. Period. Believe me.

BB: He's the only one that knew.

BC: Believe me. He knew what Duke was all about. Fantastic man. I've just seen people come into a room you know, after Duke would walk into this room right now, and it would be something like a halo right around him.

BB: Yeah. The room lights up.

BC: Really. It does.

BB: There's very few people like that. He was one of them.

BC: He'd walk in this room and — boom — the whole room would go up.

BB: Yes. I was at the White House for his seventieth birthday. And there were like not only a bunch of great, world famous jazz musicians, but there was the President, the Vice President, the Cabinet, the Supreme Court and heaven knows who else. And the spotlight was on Ellington at all times. I mean you'd have sworn there was somebody following him around with a light, and there wasn't. You know I mean this is in very fast company. You know the most powerful people in the country, in the world.

BC: But he stood out.

BB: But you know, he was the one, like who's that with Ellington — oh, the President.

BC: That's the truth. Powerful man, powerful, powerful.

BB: Betty's trying to say to me, what?
Talk about the band book.

BB: Well a big band, they have music, right? Written parts. And they number them and title

with the band, first I had to trade my bow tie to get a bow tie like the band was wearing. That was my uniform. I traded with some kid in the audience. I said, "I'll trade you ties," He said, "Oh, with Duke Ellington? Here." And that's how I got my band uniform. But I had music, a pile of music this big. Nothing numbered and nothing titled. And a lot of it would be just like one whole note on a piece of paper. And these were the arrangements. And the trombones were the only ones that had written music, you know. Why that was I don't know.

BC: But it's not weird actually you know because okay now well my section was cool you know I mean like friends-wise you know. But in the [inaudible] section if he asked anybody anything about where to come in at, he won't tell them nothing.

BB: Well that is really not true. I mean I've heard those stories all the time, but no, Cat Anderson saved my life.

BC: Well that's wonderful.

BB: Because how do you say — one night I said, "Cat, what note do I play on the end of this tune." He says, "Grab a note that sounds wrong and hold on." Yeah. And he was right.

BC: But see like Bill, he was in the band before I came. But anyway, and I was doing some recording with Duke you know so, all of his original compositions you know. So he said, "Hey Buster, you know, just take about two choruses on like this." I say, "Okay, fine." And I say, "where's the chord changes?" He say, "Chord changes," well he say, "listen baby." So that's the way it goes. No chord changes nowhere.

BB: And Duke used to say, somebody'd — we'd be doing a record date and somebody'd say, "Hey Duke, I think I got a bad note." He'd tell him, "You're a musician, fix it."

BC: Yeah. Let's find the right one, sweety.

BB: And when Cootie Williams came back, we'd play some tune and we got to the end, the last chord, and I played the note I'd been playing for a year, and Cootie looks at me and says, "That's my note." I said, "Okay, I'll find another one. All right." I mean he'd been on the band before I was born. It was his note. So I found another one.

BC: I want to say something about that band though man. I mean I have come up with a lot of chill bumps you know, like a lot of nights. That band would make you just go through the roof, when they wanted to play. They can shower down. Fantastic. You just get chill bumps.

BB: One night — were you with us that night — we were playing in Chicago in some big ballroom and —

BC: Was it the Trianon?

BB: I don't remember. I don't think it was the Triaon, but the band sounded awful all night. And it was the best band in the world, and also the worst. You know, ying and yang. It

damn, and we had about an hour to go or something like that. And somebody looked up and coming way across the dance floor at the other end of the ballroom is Count Basie's band start wandering in. Well that did it. They turned the heat up boy. Man like in one — the next tune it sounded like the world's greatest band. And it was. But they had, you know that thought, oh, here comes some of Basie's guys, we'll have to show 'em how to do it.

MW: Ali and Frasier?

BC: [inaudible]. You know I've seen us play, you know, jazz festivals with the band and everything. And it's like Duke's band was always the last one to go on. You know, nine times out of ten. It's a lot of hanging around, so you get kind of sluggish you know. And Paul gets more than anybody, Paul Gonsalves. So what happened was, and all the musicians were around and everything, and in the opening the band is kind of tired out now, you know. And the band would sound terrible to me, you know. Okay now the next night now we've got a job someplace like the Dubuque, Iowa and we'd tear the roof off the place. And it's nothing but farmers. You understand what I'm saying? You know but I'm saying why didn't you use that energy last night? You know what I'm saying? But c'est la vie.

MW: Tell us about your work so far with the Statesmen. Tell us what it means to be in such an elite group and what that means historically for this music.

BB: Well seeing as I'm the newest and the youngest, first of all I know all these guys for years. So that, you know it's like, when you know — it's not like going with a bunch of strangers. It's like a comfortable shoe. And we all know the same people, we all know the same tunes, it's an honor to be in that company. So in fact I told Buster, I added up when I got the call for this job, I added up the ages of everybody including myself and divided it by seven, and the average age in this band is 79. Now that's kind of, and then, right after I got this call, I got a call to go conduct a bunch of 16 year old kids for President Clinton. And so you know from 79 to 16 in two days.

BC: Exactly.

BB: So and the thing is though, that these guys and the 16 year olds are all trying to do the same thing. They're all trying to make jazz. So you know they're all going to the same place, which I think is just great.

BC: And Benny Waters, he's just fabulous. I mean I don't hear that vibrato, you know like a person I mean that could play the instrument you know, 93 years old. You ain't going to hear nothing like that, I mean he's very swift. And he's very commanding and — boom.

BB: We were listening to him this morning while he was playing. And we all said gee, he sounds like Coleman Hawkins. And he would be contemporary.

BB: You know I mean he's —

BC: Exactly. He's something. Fabulous. And plus he loves what he's doing so I mean it has to come out. So I mean it's like anything else, you know that you love. You keep on sweeping the street, you know, hey, you whistle while you work so to speak. That's the way he goes. Just an inner thing like anything else.

BB: And the wild part about this music, one of the wild parts is it has become in the last 20 years, it's no longer just American. It's spread around the whole world. And the people are dead serious about it too. I go to Japan a lot. I have a lot of Japanese friends, musicians. And they are just as sincere about it as any American jazz musician.

BC: And the audiences, especially Japan, are just sweethearts. I mean you could hear a pin drop when you're performing. But after you get through man, it's like the walls are coming out of the place. You understand what I'm saying? I mean very, very attentive. And it's like the same thing with Europe you know.

MW: I was going to ask you about your travels in Europe.

BC: It's just something else. I'm going to Paris, it's like December 5th. I'll be there for two weeks.

BB: Meridian?

BC: No, it's a vibe player, I forgot his name. He has a club there. I'm doing a single.

BB: Well, good.

BC: But I mean this is American, you know, like I don't have to go through that again. I mean you know jazz form, it was formed here, but it's not very supported like we do like in Europe. It just seems to me that they support the European culture here, like the symphony orchestras, other than our own cultures.

BB: Well the way they say that is that because Europe is so much older than America, they have that continuity of being appreciative of art. I mean they've had art for a thousand years instead of two hundred, or one hundred in the case of jazz. Plus I think one of the reasons jazz is not well liked here in this country is strictly race prejudice you know. And always was, right from the beginning. And when I was in college, there was no jazz being taught in any schools. In high school —

BC: That was taboo so to speak.

BB: I went to Berklee when it was brand new. It was a little, tiny, you know, just about three or four rooms that's all it was. And it was the only school in the country that I knew of that was teaching jazz at that time. Now it's you know, all over the country. In fact I've done a lot of things with kids in Japan and in Europe too. Student jazz musicians.

BC: I heard you mention [inaudible] that you know of, Herb Pomeroy.

BB: Herb Pomeroy was a teacher at Berklee when I went there.

BB: Lionel Hampton, right.

BC: There was Jack Crown, the trombone player. Do you know Jack Crown?

BB: Do I know him — he just called here.

BC: He calls me all the time. And he'd be ripping too, all the time.

BB: Every time. Yeah, Betty, he talked to you, right?

BC: He gets Sarah too, every time, about two o'clock in the morning. But I mean it's an experience and I wouldn't give a million dollars for it, and actually I've been all over the world really. And I can afford it on my own, you understand? And I've really been places that I wouldn't never dream of, like Afghanistan, Isfahan, and see the Dead Sea and the Red Sea and all that stuff like that. You know, Jerusalem and you know, so many places, playing jazz.

MW: This music, during the big band era, used to be played on the radio. You know sometimes bands would have their own radio show.

BB: Oh, a lot of them.

BC: They'd come from different hotels.

BB: Well no, but he means like Woody had a half hour show every Friday night.

BC: Oh, really? Oh, like Raymond Scott and all them.

BB: Yeah there was a lot of that going on in those days.

MW: And the music also, people used to hear this music, and as soon as they set that tempo, like you said that intro, people would dance. It would evoke a response from them.

BB: Well at one point, this was the popular music of the day, sort of. It was never really hard core jazz that was popular. But it was on the surface it seemed. But the big band era. Hundreds of bands, maybe half a dozen or a few more, ten, really good ones, the rest of them were terrible anyway. But they were out there working. But 95% of what you would hear on the radio was junk.

MW: The reason why I asked is because when you hear a band come over the radio and you enjoy the music, you can't tell what color they are.

BB: Oh, no.

MW: And the other thing that I wanted to ask the two of you, you know, owing to your experience and participation in the Statesmen is, do you think the music itself has a healing quality in it that can get rid of some of this?

BB: Absolutely. No question about it. In fact it has healing qualities in many ways, you can ask any musician, you know you've got a fever or upset stomach or a cold or anything like that, but you've got to go to work, right? You finish playing and you feel, you know, your headache's gone, your cold feels like you're not sick anymore. You are of course, but it relieves all of that, it really does.

BC: And I'll tell you another thing too I mean, and I'll question if he feels the same way, as long as I've been playing and in all the places that I have played, I mean all the big places, like he said at the White House and things like that and things for kings and queens. And I got a job in my hometown now because I live in Florida now you know. And I get the queasy stomach, I get nervous before I go to the job. I still get that feeling. But I want to keep that you know, I want to keep that feeling. Because anytime I get that feeling I say I'm not missing anything.

BB: Well of all people, like the greatest, Ella Fitzgerald, was absolutely scared to death every night she had to go on the stage. Scared to death. And she was the best.

MW: That speaks of a certain humility. And talk to us about that. About the spirituality and staying humble before the music.

BC: Well okay, well actually I don't play the trombone. Okay, a supreme being plays the trombone through me. I am the instrument. You understand what I'm saying? So I mean I just put that clearly now, you understand what I'm saying?

BB: But he's a good trombone player, though.

BC: And like a lot of guys say well, they say well listen, I can just sit here because he never called me for a job or anything so I mean, I've got to get [inaudible] in the world. That's the way I see it.

BB: It's easy to be humble playing jazz because it never comes out the way you want it to. You know, 'cause that thing is always fighting back at you.

BC: And I hate to hear myself on records.

BB: On records? Oh, man.

BC: I say I could of done this, why didn't I do that? I could have done this. You understand what I'm saying? I say why? Why did I do that? Something else man.

BB: I don't think anybody likes to hear their own records.

BC: Except Dinah Washington.

BB: Okay.

BC: In the dressing room, in the theater like the Potter Theater, like all between the shows she's playing her records all day long.

BB: But she wasn't humble though.

BC: Oh that's what I'm talking about.

MW: Talk to us about humor in the music.

BC: Well that's what it's all about. And I think you know one of the greatest players to me is Clark Terry. And it always comes out of him, out of his instrument, you understand what I'm saying? But he plays cute. He plays with a little lift and a little thing.

BB: He's a happy guy. That's his personality. And most people do play their personalities you

they're good joke tellers, and funny things happen to us too. I mean things that I don't think happen to others.

MW: Share some of those with us. Share a couple of things.

BB: Oh, I just can't pull one out of the air you know. You've got to remind me about something. Just you know terribly funny things happen. Funny sayings — oh I can't tell that one.

BC: That's something else. I'll put it this way. If I do the same thing over again I would do it exactly the same.

BB: But when you're traveling with a big band, and say you're on a bus, say Duke Ellington's band. You're on the bus with those 16 guys, whatever, you know perhaps 12 or more hours a day. Every day. For years, right? And you know you're with them more than you're with your own family. So there better be some humorous things going on, you know? It's like you're living with people that — it's hard enough to live with your own family, let alone twenty other people's families.

BC: Exactly.

BB: And some of these guys have been there with that band since before I was born. You know, long before I was born. And so like any family, they had their squabbles. You know you can't live with people that intimately 24 hours a day is what it really amounts to, and half of it in a bus, I mean that enclosed quarters, where there's no place to go, you know, you just have to pull the shade down beside you.

MR: I know they have to play soon, but do you have anything maybe about Joe Williams that — was Joe Williams with the Ellington band when you were there?

BB: No, but I've worked a lot with Joe. He's a dear friend.

MR: We're looking for just a few comments.

MW: Give us a little color on Joe.

BB: Well Joe is an extremely nice guy and very thoughtful and kind, generous, smart. We were on a ship together a couple of years ago, a cruise ship doing a jazz cruise, and we had I guess they served, anyhow somehow or other we found out that we both liked olives stuffed with anchovies. And they are very difficult to get. But Joe had this connection in San Francisco or someplace. So about a week after we got off the ship, the doorbell rings and there's a guy standing there with a case of anchovy-stuffed olives for me. You know—

BC: He sent them to you?

BB: Not a bottle or two, but a case.

BC: Well you know actually I mean okay when I first heard about Joe Williams, everybody was talking about his singing you know, with Count Basie's band. You know I mean at

Basie's band you understand what I'm saying? And so and I mean I find myself okay now I went to Birdland, I found myself just being oogle-eyed at Joe Williams. I didn't see the trombone player, I didn't even see Sonny Payne or nobody. The man was fantastic. And as like he said, he's a smart man, I mean because he didn't have, or ask for, to my knowledge, he had never had a hit record on his own. So and like "Every Day" you know he give up to somebody else, and he's still stepping. You understand what I'm saying? So he must be doing something right.

BB: He's doing something right all right.

MW: Charisma.

BB: Well he's just got it. As I say he's a very nice, gentle guy. And that comes, we were talking about you play your personality, that's his personality, what you hear.

MW: We are going to conclude this interview. It's been fabulous talking to these great musicians from the Statesmen of Jazz. Buster Cooper and Bill Berry.